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New Zealand Psychologists Board Registration Guide

Your complete guide to professional registration in New Zealand — explained in plain English, for internationally qualified psychologists.



Welcome to your registration guide

For internationally qualified psychologists, registration with the New Zealand Psychologists Board is the essential first step toward practising here — and in most cases it needs to be well underway **before** you can take up a role.

That order surprises many people. In a lot of countries you secure a job first and sort out the paperwork afterwards. New Zealand works the other way around: the title "psychologist" is protected by law, and an employer generally needs to see that you are registrable — or already registered — before progressing your application. Understanding that early shapes everything that follows.

This guide explains the process from beginning to end, built from practical experience supporting internationally qualified healthcare professionals through registration. It focuses on the things that genuinely make a difference: understanding how the Board assesses your qualifications, evidencing your supervised practice hours correctly, and avoiding the small mistakes that quietly add weeks — or months — to an application.

How to use this guide

Read it once from start to finish to understand the shape of the journey, then keep it nearby and return to each section as you reach it. Psychology registration is detailed — think of this as a handbook rather than a leaflet.

An important note

This guide is designed to **complement, not replace**, the official guidance published by the New Zealand Psychologists Board. The Board sets the rules and makes all registration decisions. Where there is ever any difference between this guide and the Board's own published requirements, the Board's guidance always takes precedence. Ethicare supports and guides you through the process; we do not make registration decisions on the Board's behalf.

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A quick word before you start

Psychology registration in New Zealand is one of the more rigorous allied-health pathways — the Board assesses each application individually rather than against a checklist. That makes thorough, well-evidenced preparation more valuable here than almost anywhere else, and this guide is built to help you do exactly that.

Understanding the Board

The New Zealand Psychologists Board (NZPB) — Te Poari Kaimātai Hinengaro o Aotearoa — is the regulator responsible for the registration and oversight of psychologists in New Zealand.

The Board operates under the Health Practitioners Competence Assurance Act 2003, the legislation that governs regulated health professions across New Zealand. Its core purpose is to **protect the public** by ensuring that everyone practising as a psychologist is suitably qualified, competent and fit to do so.

Why registration is required

In New Zealand, the title "psychologist" is **protected by law**. You cannot lawfully use the title or practise without being registered with the Board and holding a current Annual Practising Certificate. This is the mechanism that assures patients, employers and colleagues that you have met a recognised national standard.

Top tip — start with the self-assessment

Before you do anything else, complete the Board's free online **Self-Assessment of Eligibility for Registration**. It gives you an early read on how the Board may view your fitness, the equivalence of your qualifications, and your current competence — so you find out where you stand before investing time and money. We can point you to it.

An individual assessment, not a checklist

This is the single most important thing to understand about NZPB. Unlike some regulators that sort applicants into fixed pathways, the Board assesses **every overseas application on its individual merits** — for fitness, equivalence of qualifications, and competence. Importantly, the Board does **not** rely on qualification assessments completed by the New Zealand Qualifications Authority (NZQA); it makes its own assessment. That means the quality and completeness of the evidence you provide directly shapes the outcome.

Registration vs. the APC

Two related but separate things. **Registration** confirms you have met the standard to practise in a given scope. The **Annual Practising Certificate (APC)** is what then permits you to actually work, and it must be renewed each year. You must hold a current APC at all times while practising.

Qualification & 1500-hour internship



Registration in a scope



Annual Practising Certificate



Practise in New Zealand

The seven scopes of practice

The Board has gazetted **seven scopes of practice**. Which one you apply for matters enormously — it determines the qualifications and evidence you'll need to provide.

The seven scopes

- **Psychologist** — the general scope.
- **Clinical Psychologist** — the scope most international applicants from clinical backgrounds apply for; requires clinical training and supervised clinical practice.
- **Counselling Psychologist**
- **Educational Psychologist**
- **Neuropsychologist**
- **Intern Psychologist** — for those completing the supervised internship stage.
- **Trainee Psychologist** — for those in structured employer-based training (e.g. Corrections or Defence pathways).

Choosing the right scope

You apply for registration in a *specific* scope, and you must provide evidence of the qualifications, internships and practical training relevant to **that scope**. If you trained and practise as a clinical psychologist, you'll generally apply for the Clinical Psychologist scope. If you're unsure which scope fits your training, the self-assessment tool and a conversation with us early on will help you choose correctly — applying for the wrong scope is a costly detour.

The "psychologist in the country you trained" test

A key principle runs through every scope: the Board looks at whether your qualification would lead to registration **in the jurisdiction where you obtained it**. If you don't meet the registration or licensing requirements in the country where you trained, it's unlikely you'll be eligible in New Zealand. The Board also expects you to hold registration both in the country you trained *and* the country you currently reside in.

How the Board assesses your qualifications

Because the Board assesses each application individually, it helps enormously to know exactly what it's looking for. Here are the core things the Board weighs.

What the Board looks for

- That you've completed a **minimum six-year course of studies** in psychology.
- That your training programme is **accredited**.
- That you've completed **1500 hours of supervised practice** (an internship) as part of your qualification, closely supervised by a qualified psychologist (covered fully in Section 04).
- That there was an **endpoint evaluation** of your internship, or a licensing examination.
- That you hold **registration as a psychologist** in the country you trained in and the country you currently reside in.

The in-residence requirement

This catches people out, so understand it early. Your master's or doctoral programme must have included a **minimum of one continuous year in residence** at (or under the official oversight of) the institution that granted the degree. Specifically:

- Programmes delivered only through **multiple long weekends and/or summer intensives** do *not* meet the in-residence requirement.
- Programmes that use **teleconferencing or other electronic means** as a substitute for physical presence do *not* meet it either.

If your qualification was substantially online or low-residency, raise this with us early — it may affect your eligibility, and it's far better to know before you apply.

Prescribed countries — a note on fees, not a fast track

You may see "prescribed countries" mentioned (Canada, South Africa, the United Kingdom, Northern Ireland and the USA). This affects **processing time and the application fee** — applications from these countries tend to be quicker and cheaper to process because their training and regulation closely resemble New Zealand's. It is *not* a separate fast-track pathway, and it doesn't change the standard you must meet. Australian-registered psychologists register via Trans-Tasman mutual recognition instead.

The 1500-hour supervised practice requirement

This is the requirement international psychologists most often stumble on — so it deserves its own section. Get the evidence right and you remove the single biggest cause of delay.

What's required

You must provide **conclusive, clear and reliable evidence** that you successfully completed a structured, supervised and formally evaluated professional practice programme of **at least 1500 hours** as part of your qualification — approved either by the New Zealand Psychologists Board or by an equivalent competent registering authority.

How the hours must break down

The Board is specific about the composition of those hours:

- At least **50% of the supervised experience** must be in service-related activities — treatment or intervention, assessment, interviews, report writing, case presentations or consultations.
- At least **50% of those service-related activities** (i.e. 25% of the total internship hours) must be **direct client contact**.
- A minimum of **two hours per week of supervision**, of which at least one hour is individual, face-to-face, in-person supervision by a licensed psychologist.

When the hours count from

The Board counts your internship from when you actually **commenced practising** (under supervision but semi-independently) as a psychologist, through to when your placement contract ended. Internships normally occur toward the end of academic training and are distinguished from earlier *practica* by the greater independence you're given and the timing relative to your core training. Practicum hours from early in your training generally don't count toward the 1500.

Top tip — gather this evidence first

Start assembling your internship evidence before anything else, because it's the hardest to reconstruct and the most scrutinised. Aim for documentation that shows the total hours, the breakdown of activities, the proportion of direct client contact, and the supervision arrangements — ideally confirmed by your training institution or supervisor. Vague letters that simply state "completed an internship" rarely satisfy the Board.

Eligibility & documents

Alongside your qualifications and internship evidence, the Board needs a set of supporting documents. Each exists for a reason — understanding why makes them easier to satisfy.

Evidence of qualifications & training

Why: your degrees and diplomas are the foundation of your registration, and the Board makes its own assessment of them rather than relying on NZQA.

What to provide: full detail of the course content of your degrees and diplomas — both undergraduate and post-graduate — plus all information relating to internships and practical training. If you trained outside the UK, South Africa or the USA, supply *as much detail as possible* about course content; the Board needs it to judge equivalence.

Evidence of current registration

Why: the Board needs to confirm you're registered or licensed where you trained and where you live, and in good standing.

What to provide: details of your current registration with a recognised authority (e.g. a state or national registration authority). If your qualification is *not* eligible for licensing or registration as a psychologist in the country where you trained, your application will be declined.

Evidence for each scope

Why: registration is scope-specific.

What to provide: evidence of the applicable qualifications, internships and practical training for *each* scope you're applying to register under.

Identity & supporting documents

Why: to confirm who you are and link your records.

What to provide: certified identity documents, plus evidence of any name change if your name differs across documents. Translations of any non-English documents will also be needed.

Present it like a professional portfolio

How your application *looks* matters more than people expect. Clean, high-resolution colour scans; pages straight and complete; consistent naming; certification done correctly the first time. A well-organised application is read more favourably — and assessed faster — than a disorganised one containing exactly the same facts.

References & criminal history

Two requirements with precise rules that are easy to get slightly wrong — and a small error means starting that piece again. Here's exactly what the Board expects.

References

The Act requires you to be a "fit and proper person" to register, and references are how the Board confirms this. The specific rules:

- At least one reference must be from a **senior psychologist** who is registered, chartered or licensed with a government-mandated registration authority overseas — and a **copy of that referee's own registration certificate or licence** must be included with their letter.
- References must be the **original document**, signed and dated **no earlier than three months** before the Board receives your application — or the referee can email the reference directly to the Board, noting your name in the subject line.
- Referees should have known you for **at least 12 months**, ideally in a professional capacity. **Family members and friends are not suitable referees.**

Criminal history

The Board requires a record of criminal convictions from **each country you've lived in within the past five years for longer than three months**. The precise rules:

- Use the official source for each country — for example ACRO Police Clearance (UK), Australian Federal Police Certificate, Police Clearance Certificate (South Africa), or FBI/state-level checks (USA).
- The record must be **no more than six months old** and must include all names you are or were known by.
- It must be requested **directly from the Police** in the country concerned — third-party pre-employment checks are *not* accepted.

A conviction isn't an automatic bar

If you have a conviction, it does not necessarily prevent registration — the Board considers each on a case-by-case basis. The right approach is full, honest disclosure: submit the record *and* an explanatory letter. Non-disclosure is treated far more seriously than most underlying matters.

English language requirements

English language evidence exists for one reason: safe, precise communication with clients and colleagues. The Board's requirement here is specific and somewhat higher than some professions.

When you need to provide a test

You must provide English evidence if **both** of the following are true: English is *not* your first language, **and** your psychology qualifications were *not* completed in English in Australia, Canada, South Africa, the United Kingdom, Ireland or the United States. If either of those doesn't apply to you, you generally won't need a test.

The required test and score

Where a test is required, the Board accepts **only the IELTS Academic Module** — it is the only English test currently approved. The minimum is **7.5 overall, with no less than 7.0 in each section**. This is a notably high bar, so prepare evenly across all four components rather than relying on a strong average.

Validity and retakes

Your results must have been obtained **within two years** before you apply. The Board also accepts **IELTS One Skill Retake** results — so if you narrowly miss the mark in just one component, you may be able to retake that single section rather than sitting the whole test again.

Common mistake — timing the test too early

Because psychology applications can take several months to assemble, sitting IELTS too early risks your results expiring before you submit. Time your test so the results remain valid through to the point your application reaches the Board.

Cultural competence & transitional conditions

This is an area unique to practising in New Zealand, and one the Board takes seriously. Understanding it early turns a potential worry into a straightforward, even rewarding, step.

Why cultural competence matters here

The practice of psychology in New Zealand reflects the world views of both partners to **te Tiriti o Waitangi** (the Treaty of Waitangi). The Board's Core Competencies include cultural competencies, and registered psychologists are expected to be culturally competent with all cultures — and **particularly to safeguard the wellbeing of Māori**, New Zealand's indigenous people. This reflects a system-wide effort to address the effects of colonisation on Māori health.

Transitional conditions — what to expect

Here's something important to anticipate. Because overseas applicants typically haven't trained or practised with Māori, **the Board will often impose a "transitional" condition** on your scope of practice when you first register. This is *not* a mark against you — its express intent is to **support you into practice** in a new jurisdiction where tangata whenua have unique and specific cultural needs.

How to get ahead of it

You can begin your cultural-competence journey before you even relocate, and demonstrating that you've started carries real weight with the Board. Two concrete steps:

- The free, optional **Foundation Course in Cultural Competency** (learnonline.health.nz) builds your understanding of cultural competency and health literacy with a focus on Māori health outcomes.
- The Board specifically recommends the **Foundation Course in Cultural Competency (Māori)** delivered by Mauri Ora Associates (mauriora.co.nz) as a way to show you've started.

You're also welcome to make submissions to the Board about your practice in terms of cultural safety generally.

A genuine head start

Of everything in this guide, cultural competence is the step you can most easily begin today, before gathering a single other document. Doing so both smooths the transitional-condition conversation and gives you a meaningful introduction to the healthcare culture you'll be joining.

Applying & what happens next

Once your evidence is assembled, the application itself is methodical. Here's the process and a realistic sense of timing.

1

Complete the self-assessment

The Board's online Self-Assessment of Eligibility gives you an early read before you commit time and money.

2

Confirm your scope

Identify which of the seven scopes fits your training — and gather evidence specific to it.

3

Assemble your evidence

Qualifications and course content, the 1500-hour internship breakdown, registration evidence, references, criminal-history records, and English results if required.

4

Begin cultural-competence training

Optional but valuable — and it helps with any transitional condition.

5

Submit your application & fee

Overseas applications are submitted to the Board with the (non-refundable) application fee.

6

Individual assessment

The Board assesses your fitness, equivalence and competence, and may propose a transitional condition.

7

Registration & APC

Once registered in your scope, apply for your Annual Practising Certificate before you can practise.

How long it takes

Allow ample time. Industry experience suggests overseas psychology applications commonly take around **four to six months**, and applications from outside the prescribed countries can take longer because the Board examines course content in more depth. The single biggest factor within your control is the completeness and clarity of your evidence — thorough preparation genuinely shortens the timeline.

Always check the current fees

We've deliberately not printed fee amounts here. Application fees are **non-refundable** and differ between prescribed and non-prescribed countries, and the Board reviews them periodically. Always confirm the current figures on the Board's official Fees & Levy page before you budget or pay — we're happy to point you to it.

Your registration journey

From first decision to first day at work — here is the whole journey on a single page. Keep it nearby; it's the map you'll return to throughout.

Decision to move

You commit to building your career in New Zealand.



Complete the self-assessment

The Board's online eligibility check — your starting point.



Confirm your scope

Identify which of the seven scopes fits your training.



Gather internship evidence

The 1500-hour breakdown — start this first, it's the most scrutinised.



Assemble supporting documents

Qualifications, registration, references, police records, IELTS if needed.



Begin cultural-competence training

Optional but valuable — helps with any transitional condition.



Submit your application

With the non-refundable fee, to the Board.



Individual assessment

Fitness, equivalence and competence; a transitional condition may apply.



Registration in your scope

Confirmed by the Board.



Annual Practising Certificate

Apply before you can practise.



Applying for jobs & relocation

Secure your role; visa and settlement support arranged.



Starting work

Begin your new role and long-term future.

Common mistakes to avoid

Almost every avoidable delay we see traces back to one of the issues below. Read this as a pre-flight checklist — get these right and your application will move as smoothly as it can.

⚠️ Weak internship evidence

The biggest one. Vague letters that don't show the 1500 hours, the activity breakdown, the 25% direct client contact or the supervision arrangements.

⚠️ In-residence problem

A largely online or weekend/summer-intensive qualification that doesn't meet the one-continuous-year in-residence requirement.

⚠️ Wrong scope

Applying for a scope your training doesn't evidence — a costly detour. Confirm your scope first.

⚠️ Unsuitable referee

No senior overseas-registered referee (with their certificate), or references signed more than three months before submission.

⚠️ Third-party police check

Using a pre-employment background check instead of one requested directly from the police, or one older than six months.

⚠️ IELTS too low or too old

Below 7.5 overall / 7.0 per section, or results expired before submission.

⚠️ Thin course-content detail

Especially from non-prescribed countries — too little detail for the Board to judge equivalence.

✓ The fix for all of these

Do the self-assessment, gather internship evidence first, confirm your scope, and have everything reviewed before you submit. Most of these are invisible to the person making them.

Frequently asked questions

These are the questions internationally qualified psychologists ask us most often.

Should I do anything before applying?

Yes — complete the Board's free online Self-Assessment of Eligibility first. It gives you an early, honest read on how the Board may view your qualifications and competence before you invest time and money.

Which scope should I apply for?

The one your training and supervised practice actually evidence — most commonly Clinical Psychologist for those from clinical backgrounds. Registration is scope-specific, so applying for the wrong one is a costly detour. The self-assessment and an early conversation with us will help you choose.

My qualification was partly online — is that a problem?

It may be. The Board requires a minimum of one continuous year in residence, and explicitly excludes programmes delivered only via teleconferencing/electronic means or only through weekends and summer intensives. Raise this with us early so there are no surprises.

Do my practicum hours count toward the 1500?

Generally not. The Board counts internship hours from when you began practising semi-independently under supervision, toward the end of your training — distinct from earlier practica. The 1500 hours must also meet the activity and supervision breakdown set out in Section 04.

I'm registered in Australia — does that help?

Yes — there's mutual recognition between Australia and New Zealand, so you'd transfer your registration via Trans-Tasman mutual recognition rather than the full overseas-trained assessment. Your registration must be transferred before you start work.

What is a "transitional condition"?

A condition the Board often places on the scope of practice of applicants who've never trained or practised in New Zealand, tied to Māori cultural competence. It's designed to support you into practice here, not to penalise you — and starting cultural-competence training early helps.

Do I need IELTS?

Only if English isn't your first language *and* your qualifications weren't completed in English in Australia, Canada, South Africa, the UK, Ireland or the USA. Where it's required, it's IELTS Academic, 7.5 overall with 7.0 in each section, obtained within two years.

Can Ethicare review my application?

Yes. We can review your evidence — particularly your internship documentation and scope choice — against what the Board looks for, and flag likely issues while they're still easy to fix. The registration decision always rests with the Board.

HOW ETHICARE WILL SUPPORT YOU

You don't have to navigate this alone

If you choose to partner with Ethicare, we'll support you from first enquiry through registration to relocation and your first day at work — with a single point of contact, honest guidance, and help at every stage. We support and guide you through the process; the registration decision always rests with the New Zealand Psychologists Board.

READY TO BEGIN?

✉ hello@ethicareresourcing.com

☎ +44 20 4626 6580

🌐 ethicareresourcing.com



Ethicare Resourcing Ltd · Company No. 14646354 · Office 1, One Coldbath Square, London, EC1R 5HL
T: +44 20 4626 6580 · hello@ethicareresourcing.com · ethicareresourcing.com